contact. Actually, that was the feeling across the board. The top brass of the police didn't see any hope of cracking the case.

Even as the security agencies were struggling to find a clue, *The Hindu*, then Tamil Nadu's premier English daily, published a photograph that seemed likely to be a breakthrough. It showed a salwar-kameez-wearing bespectacled woman carrying a sandalwood garland, flanked by another woman and a teenage girl. The newspaper suspected the girl carrying the sandalwood garland was the assassin. But publication of the photograph, which was potentially a great piece of evidence and a lead, upset the SIT. Any lead at that stage was meant for investigation and not for public consumption. In no time, a section of the IPS lobby blamed the forensics boss P. Chandrasekharan for trying to hog publicity.

Those in the press who didn't get the picture and were outsmarted by *The Hindu* sought an explanation from the SIT chief Kaarthikeyan. How could such vital information be leaked to the press even before the investigators had got wind of it? *The Hindu*'s executive editor N. Ram's clarification of 'the freedom of press' did not make the sleuths happy. Kaarthikeyan tried to douse the fire by telling his team, 'You have to learn to live with it.'

If the SIT was becoming desperate for a clue, time was running out for Anirudhya as well. After working for a month in *India Today*, he had realized that working for a fortnightly was very different from working for a daily. A periodical, whether a weekly or a fortnightly, got to look beyond what the dailies published. The most preferred word in a newsmagazine was 'exclusive'. If your story did not carry exclusive information, the only place your copy would land up in was the trash bin.

Anirudhya arrived in the office of the head of IB's Delhi unit. It had taken him years to cultivate 'sources'—contacts such as this one. But nobody seemed to know anything except the mundane. The head of IB Delhi was a harried man. His team in Madras had intercepted a message but could not decode it. The communication was between a rogue station somewhere in the south of Madras and Jaffna across the Palk Strait, the den of the Tamil Tigers. He had rushed to the airport to catch up with his boss